The Apology

By Eve Ensler

EVIE: **(Prologue)** I am done waiting. My father is long dead. He will never say the words to me. He will not make the apology. So it must be imagined. For it is in our imagination that we can dream across boundaries, deepen the narrative, and design alternative outcomes. This is my attempt to endow my father with the will and the words of apology so that I can finally be free.

INTRODUCTION

Like millions of women, Eve Ensler has been waiting much of her lifetime for an apology. Abused by her father, Eve has struggled her whole life from this betrayal, longing for an honest reckoning from a man who is long dead. After years of work as an anti-violence activist, she decided she would wait no longer; an apology could be imagined, by her, for her, to her. The Apology, written by Eve from her father's point of view in the words she longed to hear, attempts to transform the abuse she suffered with unflinching truthfulness, compassion, and an expansive vision for the future.

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FATHER: **(Pg 1)** Dear Evie, **(Pg 34-35)** It began simply, easily embedded in the ordinary. We had a game. I would close my eyes and ask, "Where has my Evie gone? Where is she hiding?" You would squeal with delight and shout

EVIE: I'm here, Daddy. I'm right here.

FATHER: My eyes still closed, I'd say, "Oh where oh where has my sweetie pie gone? Why does she not love me anymore?"

EVIE: (crying) Daddy, open your eyes. Open your eyes!

FATHER: And when I felt it had gone on too long, I would open my eyes with great surprise and delight. "Oh, there she is! There's my sweetie pie. But I am not sure she still loves her daddy!" And you, holding on to my face, looking into my eyes, would kiss me over and over on my cheeks and forehead.

EVIE: I love you, Daddy, I love you, Daddy.

FATHER: I would hold you then and lift you and spin you. "Yes, I think you do love your daddy. You do. You are your daddy's precious little girl." And you would laugh and shriek with relief and delight.

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(Pg 41-42) My obsession with you erased all else. The family grew to despise you for it. In that sense I set you up to be hated. And that would come to be part of what destroyed you. They couldn't blame me. I was the husband. I was the father. They needed me. So they blamed you. You were the reason they were deprived. You were the reason it all went wrong. You stole my heart. You banished them to darkness. Your name was Eve and you brought the fall onto the family. You were five.

(Pg 43-45) Much to my chagrin, your mother arranged a vacation for her and me. I suspect she did this to get me out of the house away from you.

When we returned, I opened the door and waited for you to run to me and rush into my arms as you always did. You were nowhere around. I found you upstairs playing with your brother. I entered the room. You hardly looked up.

MOTHER: Evie, don't you want to greet your father?

FATHER: You walked over in a perfunctory way, sighed as if annoyed by the obligation to perform this rite, and

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barely kissed my cheek. Then you turned and without even the slightest smile or glance you went back to your game. My heart sank. This isn't my girl. What has happened to make you like this? *(To Evie, trying to conceal his feelings)* Evie, you can do better than that for your daddy.

EVIE: I'm busy now, Daddy.

FATHER: Slap in face. Door shut. Heart ripped apart. How dare you think you have the power to cut me off when I am your father?

You were a sweetie pie, Evie, but also a fierce and defiant child. I could no longer trust you to remain faithful to me. I had to exert control. **(Pg 54-55)** I withdrew my love from you. I never gave it back. I lived to hurt you after that. To hurt you for your unconcealable hurt. Thus began the reign of punishment, violence, and terror.

I vividly remember the night it began. You were standing in the den and you had just turned ten. You were slouched and had on a dirty T-shirt that I had

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asked you repeatedly not to wear. You were asking if you could spend the night at your girlfriend Judy's house. I said no. Perhaps because there was nothing about you I liked anymore and I wasn't about to reward you with anything.

EVIE: *(with attitude)* Why? Judy only lives up the street, I don't have school. We made a plan.

FATHER: Impertinent child. How dare you question my authority. My rage was boiling, my face on fire. Then you turned your face into the most disrespectful smirk, a disdainful smile refusing and mocking my command.

And Shadow Man instantaneously leapt up and with all his might he smashed his hand across your insub-ordinate face. Your whole body went flying across the room until it crashed against the wall and you dropped like a flimsy rag doll to the floor. And through your tears and shock, you smiled the sickest smile. War had been declared.

(Pg 56) Telling you this, I am filled with horror and regret, feeling for the first time how you must have

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felt. The shock. The disbelief. The utter loneliness. To be exiled, to have been made to believe you were everything and then in one violent blow erased to nothing. How could you, at ten years old, possibly handle this? Who could you turn to for help when I had turned all against you?

(Pg 72-75) I beat a child half my size. I battered a little girl. I used my hands, my fist, and belts as whips. I called you every terrible name. My intention was to humiliate and extinguish. My tactics knew no bounds.

Horrifying incidents replaying over and over on one punishing, unrelenting loop for fifteen years. Pieces of events, which cut rapidly scene to scene.

. . . Pizza parlor. Classless joint. Family dinner. Sit up straight, Eve. Sit still. I say something You immediately disagree. Stupid, girl. Boom. Fist lands in the center of your stupid face. Blood spurting from your nose. You displaying your face for the entire room. Embarrassing me. Outside I grab your arm hard. Drag you through the parking lot. I throw you in the car. Whimpering in

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back seat . . .

. . . Shaken awake out of deep sleep. Your mother rattled and alarmed. Get up, Arthur. Get up. Eve smoking in her bed. Whore. Slut. Grab you. Beat you. Smash you. Drag you down the stairs. Throw you outside. In the dark, in the cold, in your underwear. Now you'll live as a whore on the front lawn for all the world to see. Slammed, locked the door. Left you there . . .

. . . I catch you sneaking and whispering on the phone. No phone calls allowed. (To Evie) Hang up this phone, Eve. Get up here now. You will not go back to school. You will not be a cheerleader. We are sending you to reform school and you will sleep in the basement from now on with the dog. (return to narration) I drag you down the stairs and push you into the cellar. I've instructed the family to act as if you've died. No one is allowed to acknowledge or speak to you or they will be punished. You are driven mad. You leave . . .

(Pg 80-81) You became a wild hippie. You stopped

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wearing a bra, grew armpit hair, and looked a disgrace. Everything you did was a slap in my face. And I knew violence was no longer a deterrent. Even when I grounded you and refused to let you out of the house, you would defy me by sneaking out in the middle of the night. You were reckless in the car. You were willing yourself to crash, to be caught, to be arrested, to be obliterated. Your grades and performance in school were assuring you would not go to college or have any future. You stopped eating and were frighteningly thin. You were hyper and you never stopped moving your leg. You were intolerant and disagreeable. There was nothing that could pull you back in.

At eighteen you were in a madly spinning downward spiral, on your way to some irreversible tragedy or possibly death. I blamed this on your willfulness and badness. I blamed and shamed and hurt you more. I never for one moment tried to prevent you from falling.

How did you breathe, Eve? How did you survive?

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(Pg 87-89) No plea of your mother's touched my heart. It didn't matter how far you fell, how close to ruin or poverty or death. It didn't matter how much you craved my acknowledgment and support. I invalidated you on every count. And to this day, I don't know how you did it, but after one year at some third-rate women's college, you turned your academic life around and were able to transfer to a prestigious school. Perhaps it was finally being away from me. Perhaps it was the raging impetus to prove me wrong. When you came home on a break, you were filled with a new brashness and fire. You were discovering your interests and your talents. You declared at dinner you were going to be an artist, a writer. You were not going to take sciences or math, as I had strongly advised. Your arrogance and sureness enraged me.

(I see now, again, it was jealousy.) Who were you at nineteen to think you had any idea what you wanted or what you needed to study? I said you would take classes to prepare you to be a lawyer or an accountant. I said if I am paying for it, you will take

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classes that prepare you for a realistic future.

EVE: No, I will not take those classes. I am getting straight A's now. I will get a scholarship. You can keep your money.

FATHER: Boom! I pulled the chair out from underneath you and lifted it to crash it on your head. And to my shock, you lunged at me.

EVE: *(lifting her fists)* You don't have to support my classes or my dreams, but if you ever touch me again, I will leave this house forever. I promise you.

FATHER: My God, you were willing to die for this? I knew then I had to develop more effective and ruthless strategies to delegitimize this fantasy and bring you down. Battle on.

You were accepted early into the top graduate drama school in the country. You came home on a rare visit to share your excitement and enlist my support. It was a huge deal that you had been accepted.

EVE: Daddy, it is everything!

FATHER: And looking back, Eve, it probably was. *(To Evie)* I told you years ago, if you wanted to go this route

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you would go it on your own.

EVE: But I can't get a scholarship if you have money.

FATHER: That's your problem, Eve. You made your choice. It's up to you to figure it out. *(return to narration)* Right there I thwarted your foolish dream. Or at least that's what I hoped and thought. **(Pg 93)** Your mother could not understand this.

MOTHER: Why would you spend all that money on Eve's college education and then undermine her consistently?

FATHER: It made no sense. But there was a fiendish logic. The more independent you became, the more successful, the less control I had of you. I needed to disable you.

(Pg 94) You almost drank yourself to death, putting yourself in constant danger, secretly dreaming that someone would take you out, stop the pain, undo the curse. And I watched and let it happen. You lost your voice, your purpose, and your way. I never stepped in to help you. In your deepest economic distress, I never offered you a penny.

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(Pg 95-96) Here's the horrid truth, Eve. It gave me pleasure to watch you grovel without money, respect, or a future. It amused me to see you fall from such willful heights chasing an impractical and grandiose future you had independently designed. What business did you have imagining you could be a writer or an artist when I had spent my best years as a high-end ice cream salesman to pay your bills?

I had become a person who derived pleasure from your suffering. As you fell, Eve, I could feel better about myself. You were no longer a threat to my ego or worth. You had betrayed and disobeyed me. You were a failure. *(long pause)*

(Pg 112) Eve, Let me say these words: I am sorry. I am sorry. Let me get it right this time. Let me risk fragility. Let me be still. Let me not occupy or oppress. Let me not conquer or destroy. Let me be the father. Let me be the father who mirrors your kindheartedness back to you. Eve, I free you from the covenant. I revoke the lie. I lift the curse . . . Your Father

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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